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Stuck in the Quintessence of Childhood

Every day, people make decisions, choosing between apathy and action. Those who choose action create change. Change is a prerequisite for growth, and growth is a precursor to a fulfilling life. Growth comes from stepping outside our comfort zone; taking risks and embracing change is part of finding satisfaction, achievement, completeness, and contentment. Throughout *The Catcher in the Rye*, the realistic fiction novel written by J.D. Salinger, sixteen-year-old Holden Caulfield struggles with change; he idolizes the past and has tendencies and desires to preserve the present. He narrates his experiences in New York after being expelled from his third boarding school. His unhealthy behavior had started after his brother, Allie, died from leukemia. Lacking affection from his parents, Holden had become an outcast, and his emotional well-being had collapsed. Holden encounters many characters and covers various aspects of a corrupt adult world. He yearns to preserve childhood innocence from harsh realities and apparent societal phoniness. Shown by Holden living in the past, avoiding risk, and resisting the loss of innocence, Salinger employs the motif of preservation to convey the theme that people should embrace change, as change is a prerequisite for growth, which is vital to achieving a fulfilling life.

One way Salinger uses the motif of preservation to demonstrate the need to embrace change is through Holden's propensity to live in the past. Even though Holden is **tepid** in school, he **scrutinizes** the topic of mummification for his history exam paper. He is fascinated that "Modern Science would still like to know what the secret ingredients were that the Egyptians

used when they wrapped up dead people so that their faces would not rot for innumerable centuries” (Salinger 11). However, there is no “secret ingredient” to living in the past; instead, Holden should embrace change. While learning from the past is valuable for building a more fulfilling life, Holden’s excessive admiration that humans could preserve their bodies is analogous to his wish to preserve his current life rather than reach a higher potential. Salinger shows the reader that while learning from the past is essential, to make substantial growth and a fulfilling life, one must accept and embrace inevitable change rather than live life preserved in the past. Preservation is also evident when Holden visits the Museum of Natural History. Holden opines, “It always smelled like it was raining outside, even if it wasn’t...everything always stayed right where it was. Nobody’d move...The only thing that would be different would be *you*” (Salinger 120-1). Holden thinks the museum is a safe and dry shelter, not **jeopardized** by the “rain outside.” However, children play in the rain, socializing and creating memories, which are instrumental to naturally growing up. By contrast, one of Holden’s favorite places is the museum, where “everything always stayed right where it was,” showing the motif of preservation. The readers **ascertain** that nobody would mature if “nobody’d move” inside the museum. Accepting the inevitability of change, experiencing the rain, and growing up are prerequisites to life fulfillment. Living in the past like Holden shows the motif of preservation, which reveals the inability to embrace change, preventing growth and fulfilling life.

Moreover, Salinger uses Holden’s risk-**averse** predisposition to **perpetuate** the motif of preservation and stress the need to embrace change to grow. While Holden is in a cab in New York, he asks the driver, Horwitz, what happens to the ducks and the fish in the wintertime. Horwitz responds, “The *fish* don’t go no place. They stay right where they are...It’s tougher for the *fish*, the winter and all, than it is for the ducks...They get frozen right in one position for the

whole winter” (Salinger 82). Salinger **intimates** that one’s life will be more fulfilled by embracing change, migrating to avoid a harsh winter rather than being a risk-averse fish “frozen right in one position.” As humans, Holden and the readers should choose to take calculated risks rather than preserve a frozen existence. Seizing opportunities to grow leads to a more fulfilling life. Additionally, Salinger uses Holden’s risk-averse relationship with Jane Gallagher to further the motif of preservation. At one point, Holden, **bereft** of friends and self-**esteem**, **muses** in a phone booth, desiring communication with another human. He considers calling Jane, an **urbane** girl he fancies, thinking of her as pure, and admiring her chess skills, notably the **adroit** way “She wouldn’t move any of her kings...She’d just leave it in the back row” (Salinger 31-2).

While leaving kings in the back row reduces exposure to **adversaries**, it also curtails the ability to win. Similarly, Holden avoids risk and fails to call her from the phone booth, thus maintaining the status quo. This behavior reminds the reader of the motif of preservation as Holden leaves his king in the back. In order to win the game of chess or to proceed in life, even though it may carry risk, one must at times move one’s king from the “back row.” Salinger repeats the idea of preservation to teach the readers that sometimes taking risks is a prerequisite for growth.

Lastly, Holden’s resistance to the loss of innocence exemplifies the motif of preservation and shows that embracing change **augments** fulfillment in life. Phoebe, Holden’s sister and one of the few people who cares for him, asks him about his plan for the future. He responds by describing kids playing in a tall field of rye, stating, “I’m standing on the edge of some crazy cliff...if they’re running and they don’t look where they’re going I have to come out from somewhere and *catch* them...I’d just be the catcher in the rye” (Salinger 173). Salinger presents Holden as preserving the **quintessence** of childhood by “catching them” and saving them from adulthood. This imagery shows the readers that having an occupation that prevents children from

growing up is unrealistic and not part of a fulfilling life. The readers and Holden must learn to embrace the change of growing up and maximize their potential. The motif of preservation continues when Holden visits Phoebe's school and reacts **belligerently** upon seeing profane graffiti. He laments that it would contribute to their loss of innocence when the children see it. He rubs the graffiti away but eventually comes across one that "was *scratched* on, with a knife or something. It wouldn't come off. It's hopeless, anyway. If you had a million years to do it in, you couldn't rub out even *half* the "F— you" signs in the world" (Salinger 202). Holden is attempting to preserve the innocence of children by limiting their exposure to adult themes. Through the symbol of omnipresent graffiti, Salinger makes clear that resisting maturation is ultimately futile. Change is assured, and people must embrace it. Even Holden eventually realizes it is "hopeless anyway" to cling to childhood innocence. As Holden grapples with the loss of innocence, the motif of preservation uncovers a lesson for the readers to accept inevitable change.

Through Holden's ideologies of living in the past and being resistant to risk and the loss of innocence, preservation arises as a motif to demonstrate the theme that accepting change is necessary to grow and maximize life to the fullest. Holden's infatuation with mummification and his reverence for the museum exhibit his penchant for living in the past rather than using the past for knowledge to advance his life in the future. Additionally, Holden suffers from excessive risk aversion; he is more akin to a frozen fish than a migrating bird finding warmer havens. This risk-averse nature contributes to his failure to advance his romantic interests in Jane. Holden's life would be more fulfilled by embracing the potential for change. Finally, as shown by his far-fetched occupational wishes and animosity towards foul graffiti, Holden fruitlessly resists children's inevitable loss of innocence. These emotional limitations in the main protagonist were

instigated by childhood trauma. Salinger expertly introduces the idea of a common American-style stereotype that had previously never existed in American literature, precisely that of the indifferent solitary youth. Today, thankfully, depression, anxiety, and post-traumatic stress disorder are expected to be discussed, diagnosed, and treated. Effective treatment involves embracing change rather than preserving the past, paving the way for a life of growth and fulfillment.

Work Cited

Salinger, J.D. *The Catcher in the Rye*. 1951. Little, Brown, 1991.